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The Nicomachean Ethics



Translated by

DAVID ROSS

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BOOK I · THE HUMAN GOOD

SUBJECT OF OUR INQUIRY

All human activities aim at some good: some goods subordinate to others

1. EVERY art and every inquiry, and similarly every action and choice, is thought to aim at some good; and for this reason the good has rightly been declared to be that at which all things aim.* But a certain difference is found among ends; some are activities, others are products apart from the activities that produce them. Where there are ends apart from the actions, it is the nature of the products to be better than the activities. Now, as there are many actions, arts, and sciences, their ends also are many; the end of the medical art is health, that of shipbuilding a vessel, that of strategy victory, that of economics wealth. But where such arts fall under a single capacity—as bridle-making and the other arts concerned with the equipment of horses fall under the art of riding, and this and every military action under strategy, in the same way other arts fall under yet others—in all of these the ends of the master arts are to be preferred to all the subordinate ends; for it is for the sake of the former that the latter are pursued. It makes no difference whether the activities themselves are the ends of the actions, or something else apart from the activities, as in the case of the sciences just mentioned.

The science of the human good is politics

2. If, then, there is some end of the things we do, which we desire for its own sake (everything else being desired for the sake of this), and if we do not choose everything for the sake of something else (for at that rate the process would go on to infinity, so that our desire would be empty and vain), clearly this must be the good and the chief good.* Will not the knowledge of it, then, have a great influence on life? Shall we not, like archers who have a mark to aim at, be more likely to hit upon what is right? If so, we must try, in outline at least, to determine what it is, and of which of the sciences or capacities it is the object. It would seem to belong to the most authoritative art and that which is most truly the master art. And politics

appears to be of this nature;* for it is this that ordains which of the
 1094b sciences should be studied in a state, and which each class of citi-
 zens should learn and up to what point they should learn them; and
 we see even the most highly esteemed of capacities to fall under this,
 e.g. strategy, economics, rhetoric; now, since politics uses the rest of
 5 the sciences, and since, again, it legislates as to what we are to do and
 what we are to abstain from, the end of this science must include
 those of the others, so that this end must be the human good. For
 even if the end is the same for a single man and for a state, that of the
 state seems at all events something greater and more complete
 whether to attain or to preserve; though it is worth while to attain the
 10 end merely for one man, it is finer and more godlike to attain it for
 a nation or for city-states. These, then, are the ends at which our
 inquiry aims, since it is political science, in one sense of that term.

NATURE OF THE SCIENCE

*We must not expect more precision than the subject-matter admits
 of. The student should have reached years of discretion*

3. Our discussion will be adequate if it has as much clearness as the
 subject-matter admits of, for precision is not to be sought for alike
 in all discussions, any more than in all the products of the crafts.
 15 Now noble and just actions, which political science investigates,
 exhibit much variety and fluctuation, so that they may be thought
 to exist only by convention, and not by nature.* But goods exhibit
 a similar fluctuation because they bring harm to many people; for
 before now men have been undone by reason of their wealth, and
 others by reason of their courage. We must be content, then, in
 20 speaking of such subjects and with such premisses to indicate the
 truth roughly and in outline, and in speaking about things which
 are only for the most part true, and with premisses of the same kind,
 to reach conclusions that are no better. In the same spirit, therefore,
 should each type of statement be *received*; for it is the mark of an
 educated man to look for precision in each class of things just so far
 25 as the nature of the subject admits; it is evidently equally foolish to
 accept probable reasoning from a mathematician and to demand
 from a rhetorician demonstrative proofs.

Now each man judges well the things he knows, and of these he
 is a good judge. And so the man who has been educated in a subject

is a good judge of that subject, and the man who has received an all-round education is a good judge in general. Hence a young man is not a proper hearer of lectures on political science;* for he is inexperienced in the actions that occur in life, but its discussions start from these and are about these; and, further, since he tends to follow his passions, his study will be vain and unprofitable, because the end aimed at is not knowledge but action. And it makes no difference whether he is young in years or youthful in character; the defect does not depend on time, but on his living, and pursuing each successive object, as passion directs. For to such persons, as to the incontinent, knowledge brings no profit; but to those who desire and act in accordance with reason, knowledge about such matters will be of great benefit. 1095a

These remarks about the student, the sort of treatment to be expected, and the purpose of the inquiry, may be taken as our preface.

WHAT IS THE HUMAN GOOD?

It is generally agreed to be happiness, but there are various views as to what happiness is. What is required at the start is an unreasoned conviction about the facts, such as is produced by a good upbringing

4. Let us resume our inquiry and state, in view of the fact that all knowledge and every pursuit aims at some good, what it is that we say political science aims at and what is the highest of all goods achievable by action. Verbally there is very general agreement; for both the general run of men and people of superior refinement say that it is happiness,* and identify living well and faring well with being happy; but with regard to what happiness is they differ, and the many do not give the same account as the wise. For the former think it is some plain and obvious thing, like pleasure, wealth, or honour; they differ, however, from one another—and often even the same man identifies it with different things, with health when he is ill, with wealth when he is poor; but, conscious of their ignorance, they admire those who proclaim some great thing that is above their comprehension. Now some thought that apart from these many goods there is another which is good in itself* and causes the goodness of all these as well. To examine all the opinions that have been held were perhaps somewhat fruitless; enough to examine those that are most prevalent or that seem to be arguable. 15 20 25

30 Let us not fail to notice, however, that there is a difference between arguments from and those to the first principles. For Plato, too, was right in raising this question and asking, as he used to do, ‘Are we on the way from or to the first principles?’ There is a difference,
 1095b as there is in a racecourse between the course from the judges to the turning-point and the way back. For, while we must begin with what is evident, things are evident in two ways—some to us, some without qualification. Presumably, then, *we* must begin with things evident to *us*. Hence anyone who is to listen intelligently to lectures about what is noble and just and, generally, about the subjects of
 5 political science must have been brought up in good habits. For the fact is a starting-point,* and if this is sufficiently plain to him, he will not need the reason as well; and the man who has been well brought up has or can easily get starting-points. And as for him who neither has nor can get them, let him hear the words of Hesiod:

10 Far best is he who knows all things himself;
 Good, he that hearkens when men counsel right;
 But he who neither knows, nor lays to heart
 Another’s wisdom, is a useless wight.

Discussion of the popular views that the good is pleasure, honour, wealth; a fourth kind of life, that of contemplation, deferred for future discussion

5. Let us, however, resume our discussion from the point at which
 15 we digressed.¹ To judge from the lives that men lead, most men, and men of the most vulgar type, seem (not without some ground) to identify the good, or happiness, with pleasure; which is the reason why they love the life of enjoyment. For there are, we may say, three prominent types of life—that just mentioned, the political, and thirdly the contemplative life.* Now the mass of mankind are
 20 evidently quite slavish in their tastes, preferring a life suitable to beasts, but they get some ground for their view from the fact that many of those in high places share the tastes of Sardanapallus.* A consideration of the prominent types of life shows that people of superior refinement and of active disposition identify happiness with honour; for this is, roughly speaking, the end of the political life. But it seems too superficial to be what we are looking for, since

it is thought to depend on those who bestow honour rather than on 25
 him who receives it, but the good we divine to be something of
 one's own and not easily taken from one. Further, men seem to
 pursue honour in order that they may be assured of their merit; at
 least it is by men of practical wisdom that they seek to be honoured,
 and among those who know them, and on the ground of their vir-
 tue; clearly, then, according to them, at any rate, virtue is better.
 And perhaps one might even suppose this to be, rather than hon- 30
 our, the end of the political life. But even this appears somewhat
 incomplete;* for possession of virtue seems actually compatible
 with being asleep, or with lifelong inactivity, and, further, with the
 greatest sufferings and misfortunes; but a man who was living so 1096a
 no one would call happy, unless he were maintaining a thesis at all
 costs. But enough of this; for the subject has been sufficiently
 treated even in the popular discussions. Third comes the contem-
 plative life, which we shall consider later.¹

The life of money-making is one undertaken under compulsion, 5
 and wealth is evidently not the good we are seeking; for it is merely
 useful and for the sake of something else. And so one might rather
 take the aforementioned objects to be ends; for they are loved for them-
 selves. But it is evident that not even these are the end; yet many
 arguments have been wasted on the support of them. Let us leave 10
 this subject, then.

Discussion of the philosophical view that there is a Form of good

6. We had perhaps better consider the universal good and discuss
 thoroughly what is meant by it, although such an inquiry is made
 an uphill one by the fact that the Forms have been introduced by
 friends of our own.* Yet it would perhaps be thought to be better,
 indeed to be our duty, for the sake of maintaining the truth even to 15
 destroy what touches us closely, especially as we are philosophers
 or lovers of wisdom; for, while both are dear, piety requires us to
 honour truth above our friends.

The men who introduced this doctrine did not posit Ideas of
 classes within which they recognized priority and posteriority (which
 is the reason why they did not maintain the existence of an Idea
 embracing all numbers); but the term 'good' is used both in the 20
 category of substance and in that of quality and in that of relation,

¹ 1177a12-1178a8, 1178a22-1179a32.

and that which is *per se*, i.e. substance, is prior in nature to the relative (for the latter is like an offshoot and accident of being); so that there could not be a common Idea set over all these goods. Further, since 'good' has as many senses as 'being'* (for it is predicated both in the category of substance, as of god and of reason, and in quality, i.e. of the virtues, and in quantity, i.e. of that which is moderate, and in relation, i.e. of the useful, and in time, i.e. of the right opportunity, and in place, i.e. of the right locality and the like), clearly it cannot be something universally present in all cases and single; for then it could not have been predicated in all the categories, but in one only. Further, since of the things answering to one Idea there is one science, there would have been one science of all the goods; but as it is there are many sciences even of the things that fall under one category, e.g. of opportunity, for opportunity in war is studied by strategics and in disease by medicine, and the moderate in food is studied by medicine and in exercise by the science of gymnastics. And one might ask the question, what in the world they *mean* by 'a thing itself', if (as is the case) in 'man himself' and in a particular man the account of man is one and the same. For in so far as they are men, they will in no respect differ; and if this is so, neither will 'good itself' and particular goods, in so far as they are good. But again it will not be good any the more for being eternal, since that which lasts long is no whiter than that which perishes in a day.* The Pythagoreans seem to give a more plausible account of the good, when they place the One in the column of goods; and it is they that Speusippus seems to have followed.*

But let us discuss these matters elsewhere;¹ an objection to what we have said, however, may be discerned in the fact that the Platonists have not been speaking about *all* goods, and that the goods that are pursued and loved for themselves are called good by reference to a single Form, while those which tend to produce or to preserve these somehow or to prevent their contraries are called good by reason of these, and in a different way. Clearly, then, goods must be spoken of in two ways, and some must be good in themselves, the others by reason of these. Let us separate, then, things good in themselves from useful things, and consider whether the former are called good by reference to a single Idea. What sort of goods would one call good in themselves? Is it those

¹ Cf. *Met.* 986a22–6, 1028b21–4, 1072b30–1073a3, 1091a29–b3, b13–1092a17.

that are pursued even when isolated from others, such as intelligence, sight, and certain pleasures and honours? Certainly, if we pursue these also for the sake of something else, yet one would place them among things good in themselves. Or is nothing other than the Idea of good good in itself? In that case the Form will be empty. But if the things we have named are also things good in themselves, the account of the good will have to appear as something identical in them all, as that of whiteness is identical in snow and in white lead. But of honour, wisdom, and pleasure, just in respect of their goodness, the accounts are distinct and diverse.* The good, therefore, is not something common answering to one Idea. 20 25

But what then do we mean by the good? It is surely not like the things that only chance to have the same name.* Are goods one, then, by being derived from one good or by all contributing to one good, or are they rather one by analogy? Certainly, as sight is in the body, so is reason in the soul, and so on in other cases. But perhaps these subjects had better be dismissed for the present; for perfect precision about them would be more appropriate to another branch of philosophy. And similarly with regard to the Idea; even if there is some one good which is universally predicable of goods, or is capable of separate and independent existence, clearly it could not be achieved or attained by man; but we are now seeking something attainable.* Perhaps, however, someone might think it worth while to have knowledge of it with a view to the goods that *are* attainable and achievable; or, having this as a sort of pattern, we shall know better the goods that are good for us, and if we know them shall attain them. This argument has some plausibility, but seems to clash with the procedure of the sciences; for all of these, though they aim at some good and seek to supply the deficiency of it, leave on one side the knowledge of *the* good. Yet that all the exponents of the arts should be ignorant of, and should not even seek, so great an aid is not probable. It is hard, too, to see how a weaver or a carpenter will be benefited in regard to his own craft by knowing this 'good itself', or how the man who has viewed the Idea itself will be a better doctor or general thereby. For a doctor seems not even to study health in this way, but the health of man, or perhaps rather the health of a particular man; it is individuals that he is healing. But enough of these topics. 30 35 1097a 5 10

The good must be something final and self-sufficient. Definition of happiness reached by considering the characteristic function of man

- 15 7. Let us again return to the good we are seeking, and ask what it can be. It seems different in different actions and arts; it is different in medicine, in strategy, and in the other arts likewise. What then is the good of each? Surely that for whose sake everything else is done. In medicine this is health, in strategy victory, in architecture
20 a house, in any other sphere something else, and in every action and pursuit the end; for it is for the sake of this that all men do whatever else they do. Therefore, if there is an end for all that we do, this will be the good achievable by action, and if there are more than one, these will be the goods achievable by action.

- So the argument has by a different course reached the same
25 point; but we must try to state this even more clearly. Since there are evidently more than one end, and we choose some of these (e.g. wealth, flutes, and in general instruments) for the sake of something else, clearly not all ends are final ends; but the chief good is evidently something final.* Therefore, if there is only one final end, this will be what we are seeking, and if there are more than one, the
30 most final of these will be what we are seeking. Now we call that which is in itself worthy of pursuit more final than that which is worthy of pursuit for the sake of something else, and that which is never desirable for the sake of something else more final than the things that are desirable both in themselves and for the sake of that other thing, and therefore we call final without qualification that which is always desirable in itself and never for the sake of something else.

- 1097b Now such a thing happiness, above all else, is held to be; for this we choose always for itself and never for the sake of something else, but honour, pleasure, reason, and every virtue we choose indeed for themselves (for if nothing resulted from them we should still choose each of them), but we choose them also for the sake of happiness,
5 judging that through them we shall be happy. Happiness, on the other hand, no one chooses for the sake of these, nor, in general, for anything other than itself.

From the point of view of self-sufficiency the same result seems to follow; for the final good is thought to be self-sufficient. Now by self-sufficient we do not mean that which is sufficient for a man by

himself, for one who lives a solitary life, but also for parents, children, 10
 wife, and in general for his friends and fellow citizens, since man is
 born for citizenship.* But some limit must be set to this; for if we
 extend our requirement to ancestors and descendants and friends'
 friends we are in for an infinite series. Let us examine this question,
 however, on another occasion;¹ the self-sufficient we now define as 15
 that which when isolated makes life desirable and lacking in nothing;
 and such we think happiness to be;* and further we think it
 most desirable of all things, not a thing counted as one good thing
 among others*—if it were so counted it would clearly be made more
 desirable by the addition of even the least of goods; for that which
 is added becomes an excess of goods, and of goods the greater is
 always more desirable. Happiness, then, is something final and self- 20
 sufficient, and is the end of action.

Presumably, however, to say that happiness is the chief good
 seems a platitude, and a clearer account of what it is is still desired.
 This might perhaps be given, if we could first ascertain the function
 of man. For just as for a flute-player, a sculptor, or any artist, and, 25
 in general, for all things that have a function or activity, the good
 and the 'well' is thought to reside in the function, so would it seem
 to be for man, if he has a function. Have the carpenter, then, and
 the tanner certain functions or activities, and has man none? Is he
 born without a function? Or as eye, hand, foot, and in general each 30
 of the parts evidently has a function, may one lay it down that man
 similarly has a function apart from all these? What then can this
 be? Life seems to belong even to plants, but we are seeking what is
 peculiar to man. Let us exclude, therefore, the life of nutrition and
 growth. Next there would be a life of perception, but *it* also seems 1098a
 to be shared even by the horse, the ox, and every animal. There
 remains, then, an active life of the element that has reason; of this,
 one part has it in the sense of being obedient to reason, the other in
 the sense of possessing reason and exercising thought.* And, as 'life
 of the rational element' also has two meanings,* we must state that 5
 life in the sense of activity is what we mean; for this seems to be the
 more proper sense of the term. Now if the function of man is an
 activity of soul which follows or implies reason, and if we say 'a so-
 and-so' and 'a good so-and-so' have a function which is the same in
 kind, e.g. a lyre-player and a good lyre-player, and so without

¹ i. 10, 11, ix. 10.

10 qualification in all cases, eminence in respect of goodness being added to the name of the function (for the function of a lyre-player is to play the lyre, and that of a good lyre-player is to do so well): if this is the case [and we state the function of man to be a certain kind of life, and this to be an activity or actions of the soul implying a rational principle, and the function of a good man to be the good and noble performance of these, and if any action is well performed
 15 when it is performed in accordance with the appropriate virtue: if this is the case], human good turns out to be activity of soul exhibiting virtue,* and if there are more than one virtue, in accordance with the best and most complete.*

But we must add 'in a complete life'. For one swallow does not make a summer, nor does one day; and so too one day, or a short time, does not make a man blessed and happy.

20 Let this serve as an outline of the good; for we must presumably first sketch it roughly, and then later fill in the details. But it would seem that any one is capable of carrying on and articulating what has once been well outlined, and that time is a good discoverer or partner in such a work; to which facts the advances of the arts are
 25 due; for any one can add what is lacking. And we must also remember what has been said before,¹ and not look for precision in all things alike, but in each class of things such precision as accords with the subject-matter, and so much as is appropriate to the inquiry. For a carpenter and a geometer investigate the right angle
 30 in different ways; the former does so in so far as the right angle is useful for his work, while the latter inquires what it is or what sort of thing it is; for he is a spectator of the truth. We must act in the same way, then, in all other matters as well, that our main task may not be subordinated to minor questions. Nor must we demand the
 1098b cause in all matters alike; it is enough in some cases that the *fact* be well established, as in the case of the first principles; the fact is a primary thing and first principle. Now of first principles we see some by induction, some by perception, some by a certain habituation, and others too in other ways. But each set of principles we must try
 § to investigate in the natural way, and we must take pains to determine them correctly, since they have a great influence on what follows. For the beginning is thought to be more than half of the whole, and many of the questions we ask are cleared up by it.

¹ 1094b11-27.

Our definition is confirmed by current beliefs about happiness

8. But we must consider happiness in the light not only of our conclusion and our premisses, but also of what is commonly said 10
about it; for with a true view all the data harmonize, but with a false one the facts soon clash. Now goods have been divided into three classes,* and some are described as external, others as relating to soul or to body; we call those that relate to soul most properly and truly goods, and psychical actions and activities we class as relating 15
to soul. Therefore our account must be sound, at least according to this view, which is an old one and agreed on by philosophers. It is correct also in that we identify the end with certain actions and activities; for thus it falls among goods of the soul and not among external goods. Another belief which harmonizes with our account is 20
that the happy man lives well and fares well; for we have practically defined happiness as a sort of living and faring well. The characteristics that are looked for in happiness seem also, all of them, to belong to what we have defined happiness as being. For some identify happiness with virtue, some with practical wisdom, others with a kind of philosophic wisdom, others with these, or one of these, 25
accompanied by pleasure or not without pleasure; while others include also external prosperity. Now some of these views have been held by many men and men of old, others by a few eminent persons; and it is not probable that either of these should be entirely mistaken, but rather that they should be right in at least some one respect, or even in most respects.

With those who identify happiness with virtue or some one 30
virtue our account is in harmony;* for to virtue belongs virtuous activity. But it makes, perhaps, no small difference whether we place the chief good in possession or in use, in state of mind or in activity. For the state of mind may exist without producing any good result, 1099a
as in a man who is asleep or in some other way quite inactive, but the activity cannot; for one who has the activity will of necessity be acting, and acting well. And as in the Olympic Games it is not the most beautiful and the strongest that are crowned but those who compete (for it is some of these that are victorious), so those who 5
act win, and rightly win, the noble and good things in life.

Their life is also in itself pleasant. For pleasure is a state of *soul*, and to each man that which he is said to be a lover of is pleasant;

e.g. not only is a horse pleasant to the lover of horses, and a spectacle to the lover of sights, but also in the same way just acts are pleasant to the lover of justice and in general virtuous acts to the lover of virtue. Now for most men their pleasures are in conflict with one another because these are not by nature pleasant, but the lovers of what is noble find pleasant the things that are by nature pleasant; and virtuous actions are such, so that these are pleasant for such men as well as in their own nature. Their life, therefore, has no further need of pleasure as a sort of adventitious charm, but has its pleasure in itself. For, besides what we have said, the man who does not rejoice in noble actions is not even good; since no one would call a man just who did not enjoy acting justly, nor any man liberal who did not enjoy liberal actions; and similarly in all other cases.* If this is so, virtuous actions must be in themselves pleasant. But they are also *good* and *noble*, and have each of these attributes in the highest degree, since the good man judges well about these attributes; his judgement is such as we have described. Happiness then is the best, noblest, and most pleasant thing in the world, and these attributes are not severed as in the inscription at Delos—

Most noble is that which is justest, and best is health; But most pleasant it is to win what we love.

For all these properties belong to the best activities; and these, or one—the best—of these, we identify with happiness.

Yet evidently, as we said,¹ it needs the external goods as well; for it is impossible, or not easy, to do noble acts without the proper equipment. In many actions we use friends and riches and political power as instruments; and there are some things the lack of which takes the lustre from happiness—good birth, goodly children, beauty;* for the man who is very ugly in appearance or ill-born or solitary and childless is not very likely to be happy, and perhaps a man would be still less likely if he had thoroughly bad children or friends or had lost good children or friends by death. As we said,² then, happiness seems to need this sort of prosperity in addition; for which reason some identify happiness with good fortune, though others identify it with virtue.

¹ 1098b26–9.

² *ibid.*

Is happiness acquired by learning or habituation, or sent by god or by chance?

9. For this reason also the question is asked, whether happiness is to be acquired by learning or by habituation or some other sort of training, or comes in virtue of some divine providence or again by chance. Now if there is *any* gift of the gods to men, it is reasonable that happiness should be god-given* and most surely god-given of all human things inasmuch as it is the best. But this question would perhaps be more appropriate to another inquiry; happiness seems, however, even if it is not god-sent but comes as a result of virtue and some process of learning or training, to be among the most godlike things; for that which is the prize and end of virtue seems to be the best thing in the world, and something godlike and blessed.

It will also on this view be very generally shared; for all who are not maimed as regards their potentiality for virtue may win it by a certain kind of study and care. But if it is better to be happy thus than by chance, it is reasonable that the facts should be so, since everything that depends on the action of nature is by nature as good as it can be, and similarly everything that depends on art or any rational cause, and especially if it depends on the best of all causes. To entrust to chance what is greatest and most noble would be a very defective arrangement.

The answer to the question we are asking is plain also from the definition of happiness;* for it has been said to be a virtuous activity of soul, of a certain kind. Of the remaining goods, some must necessarily pre-exist as conditions of happiness, and others are naturally co-operative and useful as instruments. And this will be found to agree with what we said at the outset;¹ for we stated the end of political science to be the best end, and political science spends most of its pains on making the citizens to be of a certain character, namely, good and capable of noble acts.

It is natural, then, that we call neither ox nor horse nor any other of the animals happy; for none of them is capable of sharing in such activity. For this reason also a boy is not happy; for he is not yet capable of such acts, owing to his age; and boys who are called happy are being congratulated by reason of the hopes we have for them. For there is required, as we said,² not only complete virtue

¹ 1094a27.

² 1098a18–20.

but also a complete life, since many changes occur in life, and all manner of chances, and the most prosperous may fall into great misfortunes in old age, as is told of Priam in the Trojan Cycle;* and one who has experienced such chances and has ended wretchedly no one calls happy.

Should no man be called happy while he lives?

- 10 10. Must no one at all, then, be called happy while he lives; must we, as Solon* says, see the end? Even if we are to lay down this doctrine, is it also the case that a man *is* happy when he is *dead*? Or is not this quite absurd, especially for us who say that happiness is an activity? But if we do not call the dead man happy, and if Solon
15 does not mean this, but that one can then safely *call* a man blessed, as being at last beyond evils and misfortunes, this also affords matter for discussion; for both evil and good are thought to exist for a dead man, as much as for one who is alive but not aware of them;* e.g.
20 honours and dishonours and the good or bad fortunes of children, and in general of descendants. And this also presents a problem; for though a man has lived blessedly until old age and has had a death worthy of his life, many reverses may befall his descendants—some of them may be good and attain the life they deserve, while with
25 others the opposite may be the case; and clearly too the degrees of relationship between them and their ancestors may vary indefinitely. It would be odd, then, if the dead man were to share in these changes and become at one time happy, at another wretched; while it would also be odd if the fortunes of the descendants did not for
30 some time have *some* effect on the happiness of their ancestors.

But we must return to our first difficulty;* for perhaps by a consideration of it our present problem might be solved. Now if we must see the end and only then call a man blessed, not as being blessed but as having been so before, surely this is a paradox, that
35 when he is happy the attribute that belongs to him is not to be truly predicated of him because we do not wish to call living men happy,
1100b on account of the changes that may befall them, and because we have assumed happiness to be something permanent and by no means easily changed, while a single man may suffer many turns of fortune's wheel. For clearly if we were to follow his fortunes, we
5 should often call the same man happy and again wretched, making the happy man out to be 'a chameleon, and insecurely based'. Or is

this following his fortunes quite wrong? Success or failure in life does not depend on these, but human life, as we said,¹ needs these as well, while virtuous activities or their opposites are what determine happiness or the reverse. 10

The question we have now discussed confirms our definition. For no function of man has so much permanence as virtuous activities (these are thought to be more durable even than knowledge of the sciences), and of these themselves the most valuable are more durable because those who are blessed spend their life most readily and most continuously in these; for this seems to be the reason why we do not forget them. The attribute in question, then, will belong to the happy man, and he will be happy throughout his life; for always, or by preference to everything else, he will do and contemplate what is excellent, and he will bear the chances of life most nobly and altogether decorously, if he is 'truly good' and 'foursquare beyond reproach'. 15 20

Now many events happen by chance, and events differing in importance; small pieces of good fortune or of its opposite clearly do not weigh down the scales of life one way or the other, but a multitude of great events if they turn out well will make life more blessed (for not only are they themselves such as to add beauty to life, but the way a man deals with them may be noble and good), while if they turn out ill they crush and maim blessedness; for they both bring pain with them and hinder many activities. Yet even in these nobility shines through, when a man bears with resignation many great misfortunes, not through insensibility to pain but through nobility and greatness of soul. 25 30

If activities are, as we said, what determines the character of life, no blessed man can become miserable; for he will never do the acts that are hateful and mean. For the man who is truly good and wise, we think, bears all the chances of life becomingly and always makes the best of circumstances, as a good general makes the best military use of the army at his command, and a good shoemaker makes the best shoes out of the hides that are given him; and so with all other craftsmen. And if this is the case, the happy man can never become miserable—though he will not reach *blessedness*, if he meet with fortunes like those of Priam.* 35 1101a 5

Nor, again, is he many-coloured and changeable; for neither will he be moved from his happy state easily or by any ordinary misadventures, but only by many great ones, nor, if he has had many great misadventures, will he recover his happiness in a short time, but if at all, only in a long and complete one in which he has attained many splendid successes.

Why then should we not say that he is happy who is active in accordance with complete virtue and is sufficiently equipped with external goods, not for some chance period but throughout a complete life? Or must we add 'and who is destined to live thus and die as befits his life'?* Certainly the future is obscure to us, while happiness, we claim, is an end and something in every way final. If so, we shall call blessed those among living men in whom these conditions are, and are to be, fulfilled—but blessed *men*. So much for these questions.

Do the fortunes of the living affect the dead?

11. That the fortunes of descendants and of all a man's friends should not affect his happiness at all seems a very unfriendly doctrine, and one opposed to the opinions men hold; but since the events that happen are numerous and admit of all sorts of difference, and some come more near to us and others less so, it seems a long—nay, an infinite—task to discuss each in detail; a general outline will perhaps suffice. If, then, as some of a man's own misadventures have a certain weight and influence on life while others are, as it were, lighter, so too there are differences among the misadventures of our friends taken as a whole, and it makes a difference whether the various sufferings befall the living or the dead (much more even than whether lawless and terrible deeds are presupposed in a tragedy or done on the stage*), this difference also must be taken into account; or rather, perhaps, the fact that doubt is felt whether the dead share in any good or evil. For it seems, from these considerations, that even if anything whether good or evil penetrates to them, it must be something weak and negligible,* either in itself or for them, or if not, at least it must be such in degree and kind as not to make happy those who are not happy nor to take away their blessedness from those who are. The good or bad fortunes of friends, then, seem to have some effects on the dead, but effects of such a kind and degree as neither to make the happy not happy nor to produce any other change of the kind.

Virtue is praiseworthy, but happiness is above praise

12. These questions having been definitely answered, let us consider 10
whether happiness is among the things that are praised or rather
among the things that are prized;* for clearly it is not to be placed
among *potentialities*. Everything that is praised seems to be praised
because it is of a certain kind and is related somehow to something
else; for we praise the just or brave man, and in general both the good
man and virtue itself, because of the actions and functions involved, 15
and we praise the strong man, the good runner, and so on, because he
is of a certain kind and is related in a certain way to something good
and important. This is clear also from the praise given to the gods; it
seems absurd that the gods should be measured by our standard,* but
we do so measure them, since praise involves a reference, as we said, 20
to something else. But if praise is for things such as we have described,
clearly what applies to the best things is not praise, but something
greater and better, as is indeed obvious; for what we do to the gods and
the most godlike of men is to call them blessed and happy. And so too 25
with good *things*; no one praises happiness as he does justice, but
rather calls it blessed, as being something more divine and better.

Eudoxus* also seems to have been right in his method of advocat-
ing the supremacy of pleasure; he thought that the fact that, though
a good, it is not praised indicated it to be better than the things that
are praised, and that this is what god and the good are; for by refer- 30
ence to these all other things are judged. *Praise* is appropriate to
virtue, for as a result of virtue men tend to do noble deeds; but *enco-*
mia are bestowed on acts, whether of the body or of the soul. But
perhaps nicety in these matters is more proper to those who have
made a study of *encomia*; to us it is clear from what has been said
that happiness is among the things that are prized and perfect. It 35
seems to be so also from the fact that it is a first principle; for it is for
the sake of this that we all do everything else,* and the first principle
and cause of goods is, we claim, something prized and divine. 1102a

KINDS OF VIRTUE

*Division of the soul, and resultant division of virtue into intellectual
and moral*

13. Since happiness is an activity of soul in accordance with perfect 5
virtue, we must consider the nature of virtue;* for perhaps we shall

thus see better the nature of happiness. The true student of politics, too, is thought to have studied virtue above all things; for he wishes to make his fellow citizens good and obedient to the laws. As an
 10 example of this we have the lawgivers of the Cretans and the Spartans,* and any others of the kind that there may have been. And if this inquiry belongs to political science, clearly the pursuit of it will be in accordance with our original plan.* But clearly the
 15 virtue we must study is human virtue; for the good we were seeking was human good and the happiness human happiness. By human virtue we mean not that of the body but that of the soul; and happiness also we call an activity of soul. But if this is so, clearly the student of politics must know somehow the facts about the soul, as
 20 the man who is to heal the eyes must know about the whole body also; and all the more since political science is more prized and better than medical; but even among doctors the best educated spend much labour on acquiring knowledge of the body. The student of politics, then, must study the soul, and must study it with these objects in
 25 view, and do so just to the extent which is sufficient for the questions we are discussing; for further precision would perhaps involve more labour than our purposes require.

Some things are said about it, adequately enough, even in the discussions outside our school, and we must use these; e.g. that one
 30 element in the soul is irrational and one has reason.* Whether these are separated as the parts of the body or of anything divisible are, or are distinct by definition but by nature inseparable, like convex and concave in the circumference of a circle, does not affect the present question.

Of the irrational element one division seems to be widely distributed, and vegetative in its nature, I mean that which causes nutrition and growth;* for it is this kind of power of the soul that one
 1102b must assign to all nurslings and to embryos, and this same power to full-grown creatures; this is more reasonable than to assign some different power to them. Now the excellence of this seems to be common to all species and not specifically human; for this part or faculty seems to function most in sleep, while goodness and badness
 5 are least manifest in sleep (whence comes the saying that the happy are no better off than the wretched for half their lives; and this happens naturally enough, since sleep is an inactivity of the soul in that respect in which it is called good or bad), unless perhaps to a

small extent some of the movements actually penetrate to the soul, and in this respect the dreams of good men are better than those of ordinary people. Enough of this subject, however; let us leave the nutritive faculty alone, since it has by its nature no share in human excellence.

There seems to be also another irrational element in the soul—one which in a sense, however, shares in reason.* For we praise the reason of the continent man and of the incontinent, and the part of their soul that has reason, since it urges them aright and towards the best objects; but there is found in them also another natural element beside reason, which fights against and resists it. For exactly as paralysed limbs, when we intend to move them to the right, turn on the contrary to the left, so is it with the soul; the impulses of incontinent people move in contrary directions. But while in the body we see that which moves astray, in the soul we do not. No doubt, however, we must none the less suppose that in the soul too there is something beside reason, resisting and opposing it. In what sense it is distinct from the other elements does not concern us. Now even this seems to have a share in reason, as we said; at any rate in the continent man it obeys reason*—and presumably in the temperate and brave man it is still more obedient; for in him it speaks, on all matters, with the same voice as reason.

Therefore the irrational element also appears to be twofold. For the vegetative element in no way shares in reason, but the appetitive and in general the desiring element* in a sense shares in it, in so far as it listens to and obeys it; this is the sense in which we speak of 'taking account' of one's father or one's friends, not that in which we speak of 'accounting' for a mathematical property.* That the irrational element is in some sense persuaded by a rational principle is indicated also by the giving of advice and by all reproof and exhortation. And if this element also must be said to have a rational principle, that which has a rational principle (as well as that which has not) will be twofold, one subdivision having it in the strict sense and in itself, and the other having a tendency to obey as one does one's father.

Virtue too is distinguished into kinds in accordance with this difference,* for we say that some of the virtues are intellectual and others moral, philosophic wisdom and understanding and practical wisdom being intellectual, liberality and temperance moral. For in

speaking about a man's character* we do not say that he is wise or has understanding, but that he is good-tempered or temperate; yet we praise the wise man also with respect to his state of mind; and
10 of states of mind we call those which merit praise virtues.

BOOK X · PLEASURE, HAPPINESS

PLEASURE

Two opposed views about pleasure

1. AFTER these matters we ought perhaps next to discuss pleasure.* For it is thought to be most intimately connected with our human nature, which is the reason why in educating the young we steer them by the rudders of pleasure and pain; it is thought, too, that to enjoy the things we ought and to hate the things we ought has the greatest bearing on virtue of character. For these things extend right through life, with a weight and power of their own in respect both to virtue and to the happy life, since men choose what is pleasant and avoid what is painful; and such things, it will be thought, we should least of all omit to discuss, especially since they admit of much dispute. For some say pleasure is the good,* while others, on the contrary, say it is thoroughly bad*—some no doubt being persuaded that the facts are so, and others thinking it has a better effect on our life to exhibit pleasure as a bad thing even if it is not; for most people (they think) incline towards it and are the slaves of their pleasures, for which reason they ought to lead them in the opposite direction, since thus they will reach the middle state. But surely this is not correct. For arguments about matters concerned with feelings and actions are less reliable than facts: and so when they clash with the facts of perception they are despised, and discredit the truth as well; if a man who runs down pleasure is once seen to be aiming at it, his inclining towards it is thought to imply that it is all worthy of being aimed at; for most people are not good at drawing distinctions. True arguments seem, then, most useful, not only with a view to knowledge but with a view to life also; for since they harmonize with the facts they are believed, and so they stimulate those who understand them to live according to them.—Enough of such questions; let us proceed to review the opinions that have been expressed about pleasure.

Discussion of the view that pleasure is the good

2. Eudoxus thought pleasure was the good because he saw all things, both rational and irrational, aiming at it, and because in all things

to be really so. If this is correct, as it seems to be, and virtue and the good man as such are the measure of each thing,* those also will be pleasures which appear so to him, and those things pleasant which he enjoys. If the things he finds tiresome seem pleasant to someone, that is nothing surprising; for men may be ruined and spoilt in many ways; but the things are not pleasant, but only pleasant to these people and to people in this condition.* Those which are admittedly disgraceful plainly should not be said to be pleasures, except to a perverted taste; but of those that are thought to be good what kind of pleasure or what pleasure should be said to be that proper to man? Is it not plain from the corresponding activities? The pleasures follow these. Whether, then, the perfect and supremely happy man has one or more activities, the pleasures that perfect these will be said in the strict sense to be pleasures proper to man, and the rest will be so in a secondary or even more remote way, as are the activities.

HAPPINESS

Happiness is good activity, not amusement

6. Now that we have spoken of the virtues, the forms of friendship, and the varieties of pleasure, what remains is to discuss in outline the nature of happiness, since this is what we state the end of human affairs to be. Our discussion will be the more concise if we first sum up what we have said already. We said,¹ then, that it is not a state; for if it were it might belong to someone who was asleep throughout his life, living the life of a plant, or, again, to someone who was suffering the greatest misfortunes. If these implications are unacceptable, and we must rather class happiness as an activity, as we have said before,² and if some activities are necessary, and desirable for the sake of something else, while others are so in themselves, evidently happiness must be placed among those desirable in themselves, not among those desirable for the sake of something else; for happiness does not lack anything, but is self-sufficient.* Now those activities are desirable in themselves from which nothing is sought beyond the activity. And of this nature virtuous actions are thought to be; for to do noble and good deeds is a thing desirable for its own sake.

Pleasant amusements also are thought to be of this nature: we choose them not for the sake of other things; for we are injured

¹ 1095b31–1096a2, 1098b31–1099a7.

² 1098a5–7.

rather than benefited by them, since we are led to neglect our bodies and our property. But most of the people who are deemed happy take refuge in such pastimes, which is the reason why those who are ready-witted at them are highly esteemed at the courts of tyrants; they make themselves pleasant companions in the tyrants' favourite pursuits, and that is the sort of man they want. Now these things
 15 are thought to be of the nature of happiness because people in despotic positions spend their leisure in them, but perhaps such people prove nothing; for virtue and reason, from which good activities flow, do not depend on despotic position; nor, if these people, who have never tasted pure and generous pleasure, take refuge in the
 20 bodily pleasures, should these for that reason be thought more desirable; for boys, too, think the things that are valued among themselves are the best. It is to be expected, then, that, as different things seem valuable to boys and to men, so they should to bad men and to good. Now, as we have often maintained,¹ those things are both valuable and pleasant which are such to the good man; and to
 25 each man the activity in accordance with his own state is most desirable, and therefore to the good man that which is in accordance with virtue. Happiness, therefore, does not lie in amusement; it would, indeed, be strange if the end were amusement, and one were to take trouble and suffer hardship all one's life in order to amuse oneself. For, in a word, everything that we choose we choose
 30 for the sake of something else—except happiness, which is an end. Now to exert oneself and work for the sake of amusement seems silly and utterly childish. But to amuse oneself in order that one may exert oneself, as Anacharsis puts it, seems right; for amusement is a sort of relaxation, and we need relaxation because we
 35 cannot work continuously. Relaxation, then, is not an end; for it is taken for the sake of activity.*

The happy life is thought to be virtuous; now a virtuous life
 1177a requires exertion, and does not consist in amusement. And we say that serious things are better than laughable things and those connected with amusement, and that the activity of the better of any two things—whether it be two elements of our being or two men—is
 5 the more serious;* but the activity of the better is *ipso facto* superior and more of the nature of happiness. And any chance person—even a slave—can enjoy the bodily pleasures no less than the best man;

¹ 1099a13, 1113a22–33, 1166a12, 1170a14–16, 1176a15–22.

but no one assigns to a slave a share in happiness—unless he assigns to him also a share in human life.* For happiness does not
 10 lie in such occupations, but, as we have said before,¹ in virtuous activities.

The contemplative life is the happiest

7. If happiness is activity in accordance with virtue, it is reasonable that it should be in accordance with the highest virtue; and this will be that of the best thing in us. Whether it be reason or something else that is this element which is thought to be our natural ruler and
 15 guide and to take thought of things noble and divine, whether it be itself also divine or only the most divine element in us, the activity of this in accordance with its proper virtue will be perfect happiness. That this activity is contemplative we have already said.*

Now this would seem to be in agreement both with what we said before² and with the truth. For, firstly, this activity is the best (since
 20 not only is reason the best thing in us, but the objects of reason are the best of knowable objects*); and, secondly, it is the most continuous, since we can contemplate truth more continuously than we can *do* anything. And we think happiness ought to have pleasure mingled with it, but the activity of philosophic wisdom is admittedly the pleasantest of virtuous activities; at all events the pursuit
 25 of it is thought to offer pleasures marvellous for their purity and their enduringness, and it is to be expected that those who know will pass their time more pleasantly than those who inquire.* And the self-sufficiency that is spoken of must belong most to the contemplative activity. For while a philosopher, as well as a just man or one possessing any other virtue, needs the necessities of life, when they are sufficiently equipped with things of that sort the just
 30 man needs people towards whom and with whom he shall act justly, and the temperate man, the brave man, and each of the others is in the same case, but the philosopher, even when by himself, can contemplate truth, and the better the wiser he is; he can perhaps do so better if he has fellow workers, but still he is the most self-sufficient.*
 1177b And this activity alone would seem to be loved for its own sake; for nothing arises from it apart from the contemplating, while from practical activities we gain more or less apart from the action. And

¹ 1098a16, 1176a35–b9.

² 1097a25–b21, 1099a7–21, 1173b15–19, 1174b20–3, 1175b36–1176a3.

happiness is thought to depend on leisure; for we are busy that we may have leisure, and make war that we may live in peace. Now the activity of the practical virtues is exhibited in political or military affairs, but the actions concerned with these seem to be un leisuredly. Warlike actions are completely so (for no one chooses to be at war, or provokes war, for the sake of being at war; anyone would seem absolutely murderous if he were to make enemies of his friends in order to bring about battle and slaughter); but the action of the statesman also is un leisuredly, and aims—beyond the political action itself—at despotic power and honours, or at all events happiness, for him and his fellow citizens—a happiness different from political action, and evidently sought as being different. So if among virtuous actions political and military actions are distinguished by nobility and greatness, and these are un leisuredly and aim at an end and are not desirable for their own sake,* but the activity of reason, which is contemplative, seems both to be superior in serious worth and to aim at no end beyond itself, and to have its pleasure proper to itself (and this augments the activity), and the self-sufficiency, leisureliness, unweariedness (so far as this is possible for man), and all the other attributes ascribed to the supremely happy man are evidently those connected with this activity, it follows that this will be the complete happiness of man, if it be allowed a complete term of life (for none of the attributes of happiness is incomplete).

But such a life would be too high for man; for it is not in so far as he is man that he will live so, but in so far as something divine is present in him; and by so much as this is superior to our composite nature* is its activity superior to that which is the exercise of the other kind of virtue. If reason is divine, then, in comparison with man, the life according to it is divine in comparison with human life. But we must not follow those who advise us, being men, to think of human things, and, being mortal, of mortal things, but must, so far as we can, make ourselves immortal, and strain every nerve to live in accordance with the best thing in us; for even if it be small in bulk, much more does it in power and worth surpass everything. And this would seem actually to *be* each man, since it is the authoritative and better part of him.* It would be strange, then, if he were to choose not the life of himself but that of something else. And what we said before¹ will apply now: that which is proper

¹ 1169b33, 1176b26.

to each thing is by nature best and most pleasant for each thing; for man, therefore, the life according to reason is best and pleasantest, since reason more than anything else *is* man. This life therefore is also the happiest.

Superiority of the contemplative life further considered

8. But in a secondary degree the life in accordance with the other
 10 kind of virtue is happy;* for the activities in accordance with this
 befit our human estate. Just and brave acts, and other virtuous acts,
 we do in relation to each other, observing what's appropriate to
 each person with regard to contracts and services and all manner of
 actions and with regard to passions; and all of these seem to be
 typically human. Some of them seem even to arise from the body,
 15 and virtue of character to be in many ways bound up with the pas-
 sions. Practical wisdom, too, is linked to virtue of character, and
 this to practical wisdom, since the principles of practical wisdom
 are in accordance with the moral virtues and rightness in morals
 is in accordance with practical wisdom. Being connected with the
 passions also, the moral virtues must belong to our composite
 20 nature; and the virtues of our composite nature are human;* so,
 therefore, are the life and the happiness which correspond to these.
 The excellence of the reason is a thing apart:* we must be content
 to say this much about it, for to describe it precisely is a task greater
 than our purpose requires. It would seem, however, also to need
 external equipment but little, or less than moral virtue does. Grant
 25 that both need the necessities, and do so equally, even if the states-
 man's work is the more concerned with the body and things of that
 sort; for there will be little difference there; but in what they need
 for the exercise of their activities there will be much difference. The
 liberal man will need money for the doing of his liberal deeds, and
 30 the just man too will need it for the returning of services (for wishes
 are hard to discern, and even people who are not just *pretend* to wish
 to act justly); and the brave man will need power if he is to accom-
 plish any of the acts that correspond to his virtue, and the temper-
 ate man will need opportunity;* for how else is either he or any of
 the others to be recognized? It is debated, too, whether the will or
 35 the deed is more essential to virtue, which is assumed to involve
 1178b both; it is surely clear that its perfection involves both; but for
 deeds many things are needed, and more, the greater and nobler the

deeds are. But the man who is contemplating the truth needs no such thing, at least with a view to the exercise of his activity; indeed they are, one may say, even hindrances, at all events to his contemplation; but in so far as he is a man and lives with a number of people, he chooses to do virtuous acts; he will therefore need such aids to living a human life.*

But that perfect happiness is a contemplative activity will appear from the following consideration as well. We assume the gods to be above all other beings blessed and happy; but what sort of actions must we assign to them? Acts of justice? Will not the gods seem absurd if they make contracts and return deposits, and so on? Acts of a brave man, then, confronting dangers and running risks because it is noble to do so? Or liberal acts? To whom will they give? It will be strange if they are really to have money or anything of the kind. And what would their temperate acts be? Is not such praise tasteless, since they have no bad appetites? If we were to run through them all, the circumstances of action would be found trivial and unworthy of gods.* Still, everyone supposes that they *live* and therefore that they are active; we cannot suppose them to sleep like Endymion. Now if you take away from a living being action, and still more production, what is left but contemplation? Therefore the activity of god, which surpasses all others in blessedness, must be contemplative;* and of human activities, therefore, that which is most akin to this must be most of the nature of happiness.

This is indicated, too, by the fact that the other animals have no share in happiness, being completely deprived of such activity. For while the whole life of the gods is blessed, and that of men too in so far as some likeness of such activity belongs to them, none of the other animals is happy, since they in no way share in contemplation.* Happiness extends, then, just so far as contemplation does, and those to whom contemplation more fully belongs are more truly happy, not as a mere concomitant but in virtue of the contemplation; for this is in itself precious. Happiness, therefore, must be some form of contemplation.

But, being a man, one will also need external prosperity; for our nature is not self-sufficient for the purpose of contemplation, but our body also must be healthy and must have food and other attention. Still, we must not think that the man who is to be happy will need many things or great things, merely because he cannot be